parents, he paused to think, then replied, ‘I have not thought about any link so far, but it is a fact that all the children of my mother are single, none has married. I need to think about it.’

But there is nothing to show that he would have been anything but a great husband and a wonderful father. The love and affection he bestows on those who are around him leaves little room for any other conclusion. Perhaps he lost the chance to give the House of Tatas another Tata. But it was his choice and in deciding so, he has foreclosed the possibility of the group being threatened through divisions, as offspring of doyens have often caused, driving many industrial houses into insignificance.

Now when for the first time in the history of the conglomerate, there is neither a Tata nor a Parsi heading it, Ratan’s legacy continues to inspire the group. There may even be increasing recognition that he prepared the Tata Group to play a more prominent role in the world, equal in significance to the role played by Jamsetji in establishing the group within the country. Thus, when years pass into decades, and historians analyse India’s economic history, which is poised to reclaim its status as the world’s largest economy, much would be discussed about Ratan’s contribution to the nation’s ascendancy.

He would be remembered as the industrial leader who upended existing narratives by decrying cronyism that arrests the journey of even dynamic societies to the front lines of developed economies. In having done so, he may be viewed as the lodestar who evidenced that long-term success comes with industrial houses adhering to transparent, honest and ethical policies. In the process, he would have shone the light on a sustainable model that would have served as the rails on which India makes its journey to the centre stage in the comity of nations.

At the same time, when the layers of this passionately private personality that Ratan is are unpeeled for history, he may emerge as a fierce capitalist who was driven, paradoxically, by the need to fulfil the goals of an implacable socialist heart.